

Smoke on the water in Patna and Mumbai to Assam via Sri Lanka!

Our correspondents bring you the highlights and intriguing moments, both on and off the field, from the **third round** of Ranji Trophy fixtures.

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Bihar is a 'dry state'. Its only ground, which used to host international cricket, not so much.

The Moin-ul-Haq Stadium in Patna, home to the Bihar senior team in the Ranji Trophy 2024-25, recently rolled out the red carpet for 'Group C' rival Karnataka.

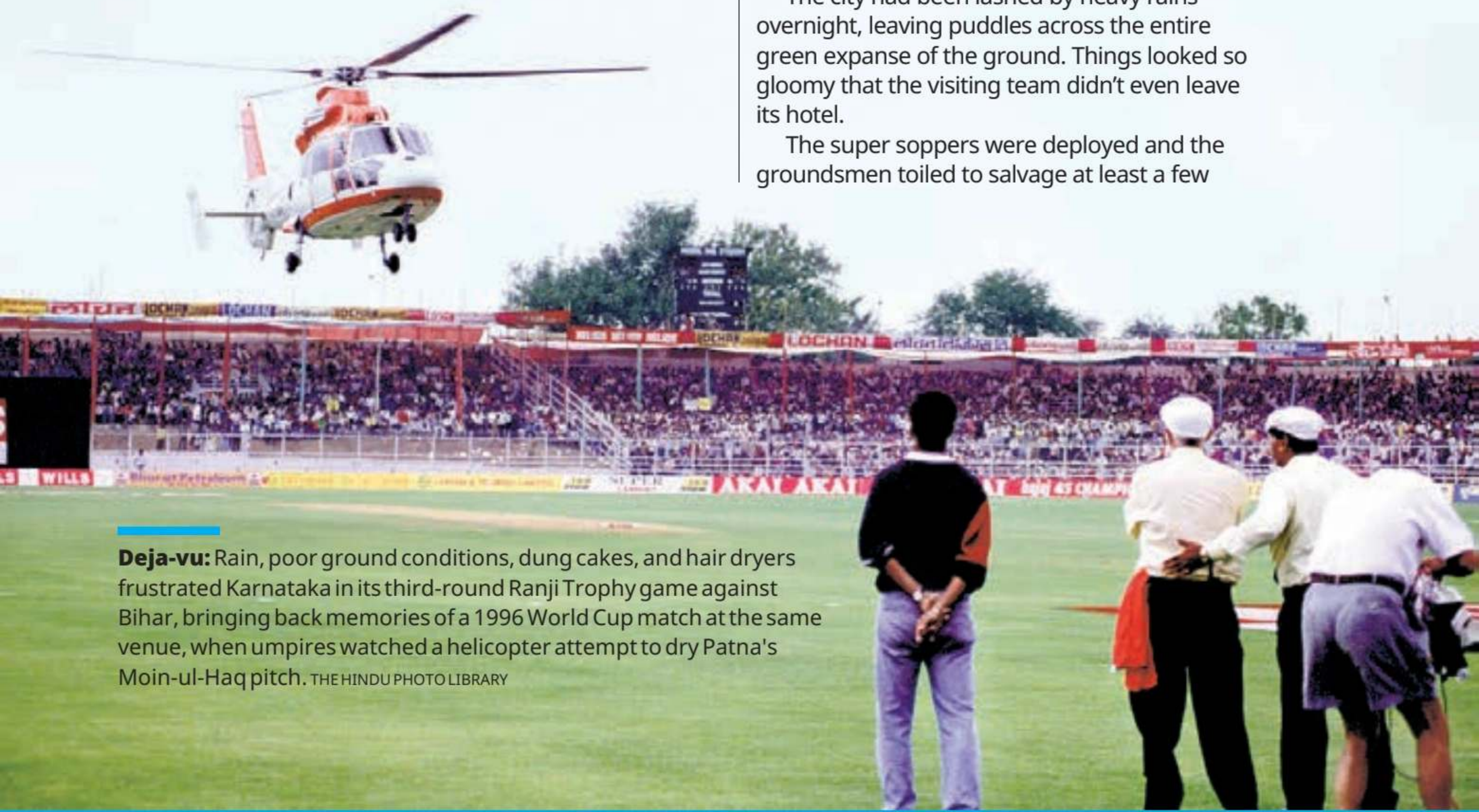
Following the previous edition of the tournament, which saw controversies over the

stadium's dilapidated state and infighting within the Bihar Cricket Association, maximum efforts have been made to whitewash the association's image this time around. Quite literally, as not a single square inch of the arena was left untouched by a fresh (three-day-old) coat of lime.

Nevertheless, Rajendra Arlekar, the Governor of the state, invited as the Chief Guest for the game, seemed a happy man. So, mission accomplished. Perhaps he wouldn't have been as pleased had he arrived on the second day of the round-three clash.

The city had been lashed by heavy rains overnight, leaving puddles across the entire green expanse of the ground. Things looked so gloomy that the visiting team didn't even leave its hotel.

The super soppers were deployed and the groundsmen toiled to salvage at least a few



Deja-vu: Rain, poor ground conditions, dung cakes, and hair dryers frustrated Karnataka in its third-round Ranji Trophy game against Bihar, bringing back memories of a 1996 World Cup match at the same venue, when umpires watched a helicopter attempt to dry Patna's Moin-ul-Haq pitch. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY